

DELHI Far Left groups have always viewed the CPI(M) as a "political impostor" and the recent bloodbath in Nandigram has given them an excuse to sharpen their attack on the big brother. Extreme Left outfits such as CPI(M-L) have been mobilising rural India while remaining on the fringes of the political mainstream. They now appear to have adopted a strategy to beat CPI(M) at its own game of street protests.

CPI(M-L) gathered tribals, Dalits and landless labourers for a march to Parliament. Although the Marxist-Leninist party's rally was against the UPA Government's economic policies, its real target seemed to be CPI(M). "CPI(M) is an agent of imperialism as much as is the Congress party or BJP," says K.N. Ramachandran, secretary, CPI(M-L). The party of veteran Naxalite Kanu Sanyal has pledged to fight the popular perception that

Left With a Widening Gulf



PROVOKED: CPI(M-L) leaders in Delhi

CPI(M) spearheads the country's Left movement. Sanyal, co-founder of the 1970s' Naxalbari movement, had been demonstrating in Singur and Nandigram. After Nandigram was violently "re-captured" by CPI(M) cadres, party leaders blamed the Maoists for precipitating the situation. "It's Brinda Karat's fantasy,"

Ramachandran says in reference to the CPI(M) Politburo member's allegation that the Left ultras had cruised on boats to take over Nandigram.

Although empathetic towards the Maoists, the CPI(M-L) insists on its own model of armed struggle. Many CPI(M) cadres are deluded with the party post-Nandigram, which is good news for far Left parties.

by Satarupa Bhattacharjya

incident. The protesters damaged cars and shops after which the furious locals retaliated as the police looked away.

During the violence, an Adivasi woman was stripped naked in the street as men watched and videotaped her on their cellphones. Three men have been arrested on charges of molestation. Chief Minister Tarun Gogoi has announced a compensation of Rs 1 lakh for the woman and a judicial probe into the incident. But a 36-hour Adivasi-enforced bandh took another life—17-year-old Santosh Kumar was pulled out of his vehicle and hacked to death.

by Swagata Sen

Hi-tech Worship

MUMBAI Bhakti goes hi-tech at the Pandharpur Temple with the newly launched website www.vitthalrukmini.org. The website makes the "God of the Workers" go digital as devotees book pujas, donate money and get the latest temple updates and travel tips on their computers. "We want to popularise the temple. All major places of worship are internationally popular since they have



ONLINE: The website launch websites. Also, this will enable devotees to get darshan online even if they can't be physically present there," says Sanjay Gaikwad, managing director of Valuable Group, which designed the website.

Eight lakh devotees visit the "abode" of Lord Vithoba, the Pandharpur temple, near Solapur, every year. Believers and Warkaris (who walk barefoot to the temple) congregate at the shrine to pay obeisance. The main day of the pilgrimage is marked by a puja by the chief minister. Legend has it that when Lord Krishna came visiting, saint Pundalik asked him to stand on a brick until he finished serving his parents. Devotees believe that Krishna still stands in this place and call him Vithoba ('vit' means 'brick' in Marathi).

by Aditi Pai



Insult to Injury

GUWAHATI On November 24, a new chapter was added to Assam's history of ethnic violence when a procession of Adivasis at

ROWDY: The protest saw major violence in the state

Dispur demanding Scheduled Tribe status was lathicharged and teargassed by police. Seven people were killed and over 250 hurt in the